

How to learn Tai Chi

These thoughts are loosely based on (or inspired by) an article in TCC Magazine number 55 by John Loupos.

I think there are four things to keep in mind as you begin and develop your Tai Chi skills: Show Up, Pay Attention, Be Honest, and Practice! These may sound obvious, but it's good to think about them a bit more.

Show Up

I don't just mean show up to class, though of course that's important! "Showing up" means being committed to what you are doing, making a conscious decision that this is what you want to do, and being ready to do it. It is being present mentally as well as physically.

Some folk think that life is "something that happens" to them - showing up is the opposite of that!

Pay Attention

Obviously, pay attention to what your teacher says and does, and to what other more experienced folk in the class are doing. But most importantly, pay attention to what you yourself are doing!

Be aware of your posture - where are your feet, your legs, your hips, your shoulders, your arms, your hands? Where is your weight? How does the posture feel? When you move, are you coordinated? Balanced? "Paying attention" is about being continually aware of these things throughout the exercise you're doing.

Be Honest

Be honest with yourself. Don't fool yourself that you know more than you actually do, or that you're "better" or "worse" than other people.

This means giving up your preconceptions and assumptions - otherwise you will get “stuck” and fail to learn. As you enter the classroom, leave your ego at the door!

Practice

Tai Chi is not something reserved for Tai Chi class. If you're to develop your skill, you have to practice every day. If you don't practice, your skills won't develop - they will lapse.

You don't necessarily need to practice an entire form. Often, I take a little bit out of the form - just a move like White Crane or Brush Knee Twist - and practice with full attention, experimenting with posture and quality of movement.

These four things - Show Up, Pay Attention, Be Honest, and Practice - may seem obvious, but it's worth analysing what they really mean. I hope you'll bear them in mind!

Softness

Tai Chi is a martial art which uses “softness” to overcome strength. What is this thing called “softness”, and how does our Tai Chi training help to develop it?

What is softness?

Softness is a quality of movement. It is yielding, but is not limp or floppy - there is an innate solidity or weight to it.

Softness is relaxed, yet resilient. Don't confuse softness with weakness.

Think of a stone thrown against a curtain - the curtain is soft, yet it absorbs the momentum of the stone, which falls to the ground. The

curtain has weight and strength, yet remains soft.

Softness allows us to sense an opponent's movement, in a way that tension and force can never do.

How can I be soft?

Softness requires us to release any unnecessary tension. We cannot relax every muscle in the body, otherwise we would collapse on the floor. "Unnecessary" tension is tension which does not contribute to maintaining the body's posture.

So, to achieve softness in the form, we need to relax everything except the minimum needed to maintain our shape and our movement. The same goes for pushing hands. In fact, it is easier to develop softness in pushing hands, and then carry that into your form. Try and see how little tension you need to use rather than how much.

A famous Tai Chi teacher said that he did not fear pushing hands with someone stronger than him. He only feared someone who was more relaxed than he was.

Softness can apply to the mind as well. A soft mind is not a weak mind - instead, a soft mind is open to new ideas, open to having its preconceptions and assumptions overturned. It is not fixed or stuck, but is receptive, flexible and ready to change.

Finally, remember that Tai Chi is not always soft. Where there is yin there must also be yang. The soft defence is followed by a strong counterattack.

Yin and Yang

Tai Chi Chuan is the martial art based on Tai Chi - which refers to the combination of Yin and Yang.

What is Yin and Yang?

These terms come from Taoist philosophy. They are very ancient, first being used about the fourth century BC.

The oldest Chinese characters for Yin and Yang involve an element meaning a hill, together with an element meaning “cloudy” or “dark” (for Yin) and “sunny” or “bright”(for Yang). So we can speculate that one of the earliest meanings for Yin and Yang were the shady side of a hill, and the sunny side.

Yin and Yang are a generalisation of the idea of polar opposites. Yin is dark, feminine, yielding, passive, descending. Yang is bright, male, firm, active, ascending. They are seen as complementary and interdependent - there can be no Yang without Yin, and vice versa. In Taoist metaphysics, everything has both Yin and Yang aspects, though in some things one or the other may predominate.

Note that in Taoist thought, ideas of “good” and “bad” are treated as perceptual judgements, not as innately Yin and Yang polarities. However, that’s not the case in Confucianism, which treats Yang as superior to Yin, explicitly propagating a patriarchal model of society.

The unity of Yin and Yang together is called Tai Chi. The Chinese characters for Tai Chi are Tai, meaning great, and Chi, meaning literally “ridgepole”. This latter character refers to the topmost timber in a traditional Chinese building, and the interpretation is something like “geographical pole” or “direction” or “remote source”. Tai Chi is usually translated as “Supreme Ultimate” or “Great Polarity”. Tai Chi is a bit paradoxical - simultaneously a duality and a unity.

Yin-Yang is not just about putting things into two different categories. What makes it different is the idea of “change”. These two qualities are seen as changing into each other - so when Yang reaches its height, it begins to change into Yin, and vice versa. Think of the sun moving through the sky - as it does so, the sunny side of the hill becomes shady, and the shady side becomes sunny.

How do Yin and Yang relate to our practice?

Yin and Yang permeate our practice in every aspect. For instance, in weight distribution, the leg which takes most of the weight is Yin, because it is strongly connected to the ground. The leg which takes the least of the weight is Yang, because it is ready for action.

In pushing hands, the push is Yang; it is met with softness and yielding (Yin), which leads the Yang into the void so it becomes Yin. The defender's Yin can then become Yang in the counterattack.

Yin and Yang must always be in balance in our practice. Even postures like single whip, where the weight is equally distributed on both legs, there is balance because the upper half of the body is Yang while the lower half is Yin.

It is important to be able to distinguish Yin and Yang in our practice. Don't over-think it, just be aware.

Protrusions and deficiencies

Last time, I read from the poem by Wang Ts'ung-Yueh. In the poem there is a line

It must not be overdone or fall short

The same instruction appears in the Chang San-Feng classic:

Do not have any deficient places

Do not have any hollow or protruding places.

What does this mean? What are protrusions and deficiencies in Tai Chi?

Basically, movements and postures must not be excessive, neither must they be truncated. As an example, let's take Brush Knee Twist.

Reaching too far or over-stretching is seen as a “protrusion”. Similarly, sticking your bum out is a protrusion.

Not completing the move by going onto the next one too quickly is seen as hollow or a “deficiency”. Capsizing the front knee so it is not above the foot is seen the same way.

These concepts can also be applied to pushing hands. For instance, if there is something deficient about your response to a push, it will allow a partner inside your guard. If you over-reach with your push - a protrusion - you may overbalance.

Overall, these verses tell us that accuracy in the form and attention to detail in pushing hands are essential.

It can also apply to the mind. When our mind chases after something, that's a protrusion. Maybe you're looking forward to your favourite move, coming up in a few seconds, or perhaps you're excitedly anticipating reaching the end of whichever form you're learning. A deficiency is when your mind resists something - perhaps there's a move you think is awkward, or there's a part of the syllabus you don't much enjoy. Be aware of these feelings, notice and acknowledge them, and return to just practicing.

Focus

Last time, I talked about protrusions and deficiencies, and I related those concepts not only to physical departures from the ideal, but also to the mind. I talked about how, sometimes, the mind chases after some things, and resists others.

You may find, when practicing, that your mind tends to float away, and you find yourself thinking about what you're going to do later today, or wondering how your partner is getting on, or what you're going to have for lunch, or you might be thinking “I'm doing it better than her”. Or you're simply looking forward to the next bit of the form.

As we practice, we should try to be present in the moment, focussed on what we're doing, listening to our own body (and our partner's body, if it is a partner exercise). Try to build your awareness of these things, rather than anticipating the next move.

Of course, everyone (including me!) will get distracted. When you notice that your thoughts have wandered, instead of kicking yourself, say to yourself "oh good, I've noticed what my mind is doing!". The act of noticing, and then returning to your practice in the moment, is something to be quietly pleased about.

There's another aspect to this, which is when the mind, instead of chasing after something, instead finds something which it resists. It might be something you don't much like - for instance some people have a resistance to the self-defence aspects of Tai Chi, or maybe there's a posture or move you find too awkward, or you think some of the Yin-Yang philosophy is nonsense. Again, it's important to notice and acknowledge these feelings, and simply return to practicing.

When you do encounter this mental resistance to something, treat it as a learning opportunity. The learning might be to do with Tai Chi, or it might be an opportunity to learn something about yourself. But the most important thing is to return to just practicing.

This use of mental resistance as a learning opportunity links to a concept called "investing in loss" which I'll talk about next week.

Pushing Hands Aphorisms

The Tai Chi Classics have much to say about pushing hands. Here are three aphorisms which particularly appeal to me.

When you are going forward, your opponent should feel hemmed in.

When you are defending, your opponent should feel they have a million miles to go.

It's all too easy to be complacent in pushing hands, and go through the motions in a compliant way. However, it is good to vary it now and again. You could try pushing quite firmly, and when defending, try to make it as soft and light as possible, without letting the push come inside your guard.

You can defend against a force of 1000 pounds with just four ounces of effort.

Of course, the original poem used old Chinese units of measurement (Catties and Taels), not pounds and ounces, but the meaning is clear. Divert, rather than oppose, your partner's push.

A feather cannot be added. A fly cannot land

Why on earth are they talking about feathers and flies? The idea is that you should be so sensitive to the forces acting on you that even a feather falling on your shoulder or a fly landing on your arm is sufficient to set you into motion. Of course, no human can possibly attain such a level of sensitivity, but it gives you something to aim for!

Breathing

Some martial arts, and some body arts like Yoga, place heavy emphasis on how to breathe. In fact, there are one or two styles of Tai Chi which also emphasise the breath. However in most Tai Chi styles, all that is asked of us is that we breathe naturally.

Breathing is semi-automatic, and we're often not aware of how we're doing it. Natural breathing (for most people) is breathing through the nose, with the mouth closed. The tip of the tongue should be relaxed, resting lightly on the roof of the mouth or the back of the upper teeth. The breath is steady, without great big expansion of the ribcage. Think of a tortoise - it cannot expand its lungs outwards because of its hard shell

- the only possible direction for expansion is lengthwise.

Deeper breaths can be taken by focussing on drawing the diaphragm downward. This is sometimes called abdominal breathing, but of course the abdomen does not take in air. What happens is that the diaphragm pushes some of the internal organs outwards, giving the appearance of air flowing into the abdomen.

You can learn to control what part of the lungs are involved in breathing - you can place your hands on your body and feel your ribcage or abdomen expanding (or not) as you use different parts of your lungs.